Core CHOMP!

Taking small daily bites of challenging ELA Common Core standards.

7th Grade English Language Arts
A FREE Sample of Ten Core CHOMP! Exercises

ELA Core Plans

Teacher-Written Standards-Based Lesson Plans

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Introduction

Purpose

The purpose of ***Core CHOMP!*** is to provide three questions a day that are based on the Common Core State Standards for seventh grade English language arts. These comprehensive exercises reinforce the Standards and will increase your students' reading and writing skills, often challenging them with complex texts as they read and comprehend literature including stories, poems, and informational text.

Format

Core CHOMP! can be used as a warm-up activity, a homework assignment, or as a closure for your class. There are 180 standards-based exercises, one for every day of the school year, and they are built around a rotating five-day pattern. They will read a **poem** on day one, a complex **fiction passage** on day two, and an **informational text** on day three. Days four and five will address **writing, research,** and **language**.

We designed the exercises in ***Core CHOMP!*** so that by the end of the year, students will have read, comprehended, and been asked to provide evidence of their analysis of a wide variety of literature and informational texts as well as spent time thinking through the writing and research process.

Many of the ***Core CHOMP!*** exercises are not easy, but neither are the requirements of the Common Core State Standards. The program of daily exercises helps students gradually gain mastery of a wide variety of material, as required in the Standards. These exercises will require your students to complete tasks including the following:

- rewrite texts using effective techniques and well-chosen words and details
- make inferences on what they have read
- support answers with text
- develop a claim using valid reasoning and relevant and sufficient evidence
- analyze the author's purpose and literary elements
- determine themes or central ideas of texts
- assess whether reasoning provided in a text is sound or not
- determine the meaning of words, phrases, and figurative language
- analyze text structure used by an author
- and much more

If you choose to use this as a warm-up or closing for your class, we suggest giving your students several minutes to work through the questions on their own before going over them as a class. If you choose to use this as a homework assignment, we suggest you go over it in class the next day. Either way, you will find that students are repeatedly exposed to material that reinforces the Standards.

How to Provide Student Handouts

Print four *Core Chomps* to a page and copy them front and back to give to the students. That way, students will have eight days-worth of *Chomps* in their binders. This prevents you from having to hand out a new one every single day.

You can print four to a page from an Adobe Reader file by clicking *File* then *Print*. Select the pages you want to print under *Print Range* (pages from…). Then, click on the *Layout* tab. Choose 4 in the *Pages per sheet* drop-down menu. Select OK to print.

Have the students keep these in a binder or folder.

Chomp 1 

The Maze of Sleep

Sleep is a pathless labyrinth,
Dark to the gaze of moons and suns,
Through which the colored clue of dreams,
A gossamer thread, obscurely runs.

By Clark Ashton Smith

Labyrinth: complex system of paths or tunnels in which it is easy to get lost

Gossamer: characterized by unusual lightness and delicacy

Obscure: not clearly understood or expressed

1. **Explain the metaphor in this poem. Use the provided definitions to help you.**

_____

_____

_____

2. **Why does the poet most likely refer to sleep as "pathless"?**

_____

_____

3. **Think of something else that can be compared to a maze. Write a short poem about it.**
   Examples: The Maze of Love, The Maze of Fear

Chomp 2 

It was, in fact, a house that would create ghosts. The atmosphere was alive with that strange sensation of disembodied spirits which some very old houses seem to possess. Narrow, slit-like windows in perfect keeping with the architecture and the needs of the period in which it was built—if not with modern ideas of hygiene and health—kept the rooms dark and musty. When Nigel first entered the place through the great front door thrown open by the solemn-faced butler, who he learned had been kept on from his uncle's time, he felt as though he were entering his own tomb. When the door shut he shuddered as the light and sunshine vanished.

-From: The Riddle of the Frozen Flame By Mary E. and Thomas W. Hanshew

1. List some words that the author of this passage uses to create an eerie tone.

_____

_____

2. The reader can infer _____.

a. that the character is on a ghost hunt
b. that the character has never been to this house before
c. that the character is a ghost himself
d. that the character hardly slept a wink the first night

When Nigel first entered the place through the great front door thrown open by the solemn-faced butler, who he learned had been kept on from his uncle's time, he felt as though he were entering his own tomb.

3. What is this butler like? What does solemn-faced mean?

_____

_____

Chomp 3 

The dinosaurs were by no means confined to North America, although the western United States seem to have been their headquarters, but ranged pretty much over the world, for their remains have been found in every continent, even in far-off New Zealand.

In one point of time they ranged from the Trias to the Upper Cretaceous. They were huge forms who stalked by the sea-shore, browsed amid the swamps, or disported themselves along the reedy margins of lakes and rivers.

They had their day, a day of many thousand years, and then passed away, giving place to the superior race of mammals which was just springing into being when the huge dinosaurs were in the heyday of their existence.

And it does seem as if in the dim and distant past, as in the present, brains were a huge factor in the struggle for supremacy; for, though these reptiles were giants in size, they were dwarfs in intellect.

The smallest human brain that is thought to be compatible with life itself weighs a little over ten ounces, the smallest that can exist with reasoning powers is two pounds; this in a creature weighing from one hundred twenty to one hundred fifty pounds.

What do we find among dinosaurs? The spesius, or Claosaurus, which may have walked where Baltimore now stands, was twenty-five feet in length and stood a dozen feet high in his bare feet, had a brain smaller than a man's clenched fist, weighing less than one pound.
Brontosaurus, in some respects the biggest brute that ever walked, was but little better off, and Triceratops and his relatives, creatures having twice the bulk of an elephant, weighing probably over ten tons, possessed a brain weighing not over two pounds!

How much of what we term intelligence could such a creature possess—what was the extent of its reasoning powers? Judging from our own standpoint and the small amount of intellect apparent in some humans with much larger brains, these big reptiles must have known just about enough to have eaten when they were hungry; anything more was superfluous.

1. What does this text say about the intelligence of dinosaurs? Use the text to support your answer.

_____

2. What is the central idea of the first two paragraphs?

a. Dinosaur remains have been found in every continent.
b. Dinosaurs have small brains.
c. The dinosaurs were all over the world.
d. Most of the dinosaurs were in North America.

3. How does the author of this passage determine the intelligence of dinosaurs?

a. by using scientific evidence of tests on brain matter of dinosaurs
b. by comparing the size of human brains to those of dinosaurs
c. by analyzing the diets of dinosaurs
d. by completing extensive research of many opinions of anthropologist

Chomp 4

Should the death penalty be used in the United States?

1. **If you were writing an argumentative essay on this topic, and your claim was that the death penalty is wrong, which of the following would you <u>not</u> include in your essay?**
   a. statistics that show the cost and financial burden of using the death penalty
   b. the fact that sometimes innocent people are given the death penalty
   c. the morality of the death penalty
   d. statistics that show that the death penalty decreases crime

2. **If your claim was in favor of the death penalty, what reasons could you use to support it? (List three reasons below.)**

Reason 1	Reason 2	Reason 3

Since 1973, over 130 people have been released from death row with evidence of their innocence. (Staff Report, House Judiciary Subcommittee on Civil & Constitutional Rights, Oct. 1993, with updates from DPIC).

3. **If you were going to use the information above, what would your claim be?**
   a. The death penalty is wrong.
   b. The death penalty is a fair punishment.

Chomp 5 

Anteaters are commonly known for eating Ants and Termites. Another common name for the anteater is ant bear, and the individual species have other names in English and other languages. The anteaters are more closely related to the sloths than to any other group of mammals. All anteaters have elongated snouts equipped with a thin tongue that can be extended to a length greater than the length of the head. Anteaters are edentate. They have lips but no teeth.

Compound sentence – two sentences joined together using a semicolon (;) or a conjunction (and, or, but, etc.)

1. **Which of the following is a compound sentence?**
    a. Another common name for the anteater is ant bears, and the individual species have other names in English and other languages.
    b. The anteaters are more closely related to the sloths than to any other group of mammals.
    c. All anteaters have elongated snouts equipped with a thin tongue that can be extended to a length greater than the length of the head.
    d. Anteaters have lips but no teeth.

2. **How should sentence one be edited?**
    a. Anteaters are commonly known for: eating Ants and Termites.
    b. Anteaters are commonly known for eating ants and termites.
    c. Anteaters are commonly known, for eating ants and Termites.
    d. Anteaters are commonly known for eating. Ants and Termites.

Anteaters are edentate.

3. **What does the root -dent in the word edentate tell the reader?**
    a. The anteater has lips.
    b. The anteater has no teeth.
    c. The anteater eats ants.
    d. The anteater has a long snout.

Chomp 6 

I'm Nobody! Who Are You?

By Emily Dickinson

I'm Nobody! Who are you?
Are you – Nobody too?
Then there's a pair of us? –
Don't tell! They'd advertise – you know!
How dreary – to be – Somebody!
How public – like a Frog –
To tell one's name – the livelong June –
To an admiring Bog!

1. What does the frog symbolize in this poem?

a. the "somebodies"
b. the "nobodies"
c. a lily pad
d. other people

2. Which of the following may be a reason that Emily Dickinson used so many hyphens and end punctuation in this poem?

a. to create a joyful tone
b. to cause the poem to be read with anxious pauses like a secret is sometimes told
c. to cause the poem to be read with fear because of the poem's suspense
d. to cause the reader to rest while reading it

3. What does Emily Dickinson mean in this poem when she writes, "How dreary to be somebody!"

_____

Chomp 7 

The Bald Man and the Fly

A Fly bit the bare head of a Bald Man who, endeavoring to destroy it, gave himself a heavy slap. Escaping, the Fly said mockingly, "You who have wished to revenge, even with death, the prick of a tiny insect, see what you have done to yourself to add insult to injury?" The Bald Man replied, "I can easily make peace with myself because I know there was no intention to hurt. But you, an ill-favored and contemptible insect who delights in sucking human blood, I wish that I could have killed you even if I had incurred a heavier penalty."

1. **In the end, what is the bald man saying to the fly?**
   a. He wished he would have killed the fly even if it meant more harm to himself.
   b. He would try to destroy the fly the next time he saw it.
   c. All flies are terrible insects and do not deserve to have wings.
   d. Because he hit himself, the fly should have been killed.

2. **Which of the following best describes the fly in this story?**
   a. playful
   b. sinister
   c. jocular
   d. contemptuous

   Underline a passage that supports your answer.

3. **Which word below could replace the underlined word *endeavoring* in the passage?**
   a. building up
   b. memorizing
   c. attempting
   d. jumping

Chomp 8 

Snowboarding is becoming an increasingly popular winter sport. In the 1960s, a man named Shermin Poppen was outside his house one day sledding with his daughters, when his 11 year old was going down the hill, standing on her old sled. Poppen then ran inside his shop and bound two skis together. Poppen used a string and tied it to the nose of the board so the rider could have control of the board. Poppen's wife called it the Snurfer, and soon after creating the first one, Poppen's daughters' friends all wanted one.These “Snurfers”, two skis tied together, were sold to thousands.

Through the years, the board and the sport have evolved. Today, snowboarders descend a slope that is covered with snow while standing on a board attached to a rider’s feet using a special boot that is set onto a mounted binding. Through the 1980s and 1990s, snowboarding competitions were on the rise. Ski resorts benefited greatly from these snowboarding fanatics. Some of these ski resorts banned snowboarding because they were fearful of the dangers that this new sport could hold. Today, however, snowboarding is one of the fastest growing sports in America. It really is a great winter activity! It continues to become even more popular each year.

1. **What is the main idea of this passage?**
   a. Snowboarding is a dangerous sport, and not many people are willing to take the risks it involves.
   b. Some ski resorts banned snowboarding because of the potential dangers it poses.
   c. Snowboarding began with the “snurfer” and thousands of these were sold in the 1960s.
   d. The history of snowboarding dates back to the 1960s, and the sport is becoming increasingly popular today.

2. **What does the underlined word fanatics mean?**
   a. geniuses
   b. athletes
   c. experts
   d. enthusiasts

3. **Find and underline the sentence from the passage that explains how the snurfer has evolved.**

Chomp 9 

Use this information to answer the next two questions.

Jason's English teacher wants everyone in the class to write an essay that answers the following question:

Should the legal driving age be lowered? Explain why or why not.

1. **What is the *best* way for Jason to get started on his essay?**
   - **a.** ask his friends how they are going to answer the question
   - **b.** create an outline based on opinions in the community
   - **c.** look up different types of cars on the Internet
   - **d.** think about the topic and jot down some pros and cons

2. **In order to be effective, what will Jason's paper need to be?**
   - **a.** narrative
   - **b.** persuasive
   - **c.** informational
   - **d.** argumentative

3. **What would your "claim" be for this prompt? List some of your reasons for or against lowering the legal driving age.**

Reasons for	Reasons against

Chomp 10 

Modifiers are words or groups of words that describe, limit, or modify other words or groups of words in a sentence. In the following sentences, the modifiers are underlined.

- I saw a green monster.
- She tiptoed slowly.
- Pumping his legs as fast as he could, Jake won the race.

Writers must make sure their modifiers are in the right place. By rule, modifiers must modify the closest word or group of words in a sentence. If too much distance separates a modifier and the words it describes, the modifier is misplaced.

Example of sentence with a misplaced modifier

Covered in dirt, my mom gave the dog a bath.

In this sentence, it sounds like the mom is covered in dirt!

Correction

My mom gave the dog covered in dirt a bath.

Read the following three sentences. Identify what is wrong, and correct each sentence.

1. **Every day, my mom serves cookies to my friends on paper plates.**

   _____

2. **We ate the popcorn that we had bought slowly.**

   _____

3. **Covered with warm chocolate, the waitress served the hot cake to the customers.**

   _____

Answer Key
ARA= Accept Reasonable Answers

Chomp 1

1. Explain the metaphor in this poem. Use the provided definitions to help you.

ARA

Possible: A labyrinth is a maze and like sleep it is easy to get lost in; sleep is when you can get rest and peace

2. Why does the poet most likely refer to sleep as "pathless"?

ARA

Possible: You never know where your dreams will take you.

1. Think of something else that can be compared to a maze. Write a short poem about it.

Examples: The Maze of Love, The Maze of Fear

ARA

Possible:

Fear is a Maze
eerie and dark
Often fear comes
from nowhere
and makes us feel
lost

Chomp 2

1. List some words that the author of this passage uses to create an eerie tone.

disembodied spirits, dark, musty, solemn-faced, tomb, shuddered

2. The reader can infer _____.

a. that the character is on a ghost hunt
b. that the character has never been to this house before
c. that the character is a ghost himself
d. that the character hardly slept a wink the first night

When Nigel first entered the place through the great front door thrown open by the solemn-faced butler, who he learned had been kept on from his uncle's time, he felt as though he were entering his own tomb.

3. What is this butler like? What does solemn-faced mean?

He is serious.

Solemn-faced means that his face has a serious, emotionless look.

Chomp 3

1. What does this text say about the intelligence of dinosaurs? Use the text to support your answer.

Dinosaurs were giants in size, but they were dwarfs in intelligence.

2. What is the central idea of the first two paragraphs?

a. Dinosaur remains have been found in every continent.
b. Dinosaurs have small brains.
c. The dinosaurs were all over the world.
d. Most of the dinosaurs were in North America.

3. How does the author of this passage determine the intelligence of dinosaurs?

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Chomp 4

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1. **If you were writing an argumentative essay on this topic, and your claim was that the death penalty is wrong, which of the following would you <u>not</u> include in your essay?**
   a. statistics that show the cost and financial burden of using the death penalty
   b. the fact that sometimes innocent people are given the death penalty
   c. the morality of the death penalty
   d. statistics that show that the death penalty decreases crime

2.If your claim was in favor of the death penalty, what reasons could you use to support it? (List three reasons below.) ARA – possible:

Reason 1	Reason 2	Reason 3
states that use the death penalty have lower crime rates	**helps to alleviate our crowed prisons**	**gives closure to victims**

Since 1973, over 130 people have been released from death row with evidence of their innocence. (Staff Report, House Judiciary Subcommittee on Civil & Constitutional Rights, Oct. 1993, with updates from DPIC).

3.If you were going to use the information above, what would your claim be?

   a. The death penalty is wrong.
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Chomp 5

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Anteaters are edentate.

3. What does the root *-dent* in the word *edentate* tell the reader?
   a. The anteater has lips.
   b. **The anteater has no teeth.**
   c. The anteater eats ants.
   d. The anteater has a long snout.

Chomp 6

1. What does the frog symbolize in this poem?

a. the "somebodies"
b. the "nobodies"
c. a lily pad
d. other people

2. Which of the following may be a reason that Emily Dickinson used so many hyphens and end punctuation in this poem?

a. to create a joyful tone
b. to cause the poem to be read with anxious pauses like a secret is sometimes told
c. to cause the poem to be read with fear because of the poem's suspense
d. to cause the reader to rest while reading it

3. What does Emily Dickinson mean in this poem when she writes, "How dreary to be somebody!"

She means that it is no fun to be a public figure because everyone knows all about you.

Chomp 7

1. In the end, what is the bald man saying to the fly?

a. He wished he could have killed the fly even if it meant more harm to himself.
b. He would try to destroy the fly the next time he saw it.
c. All flies are terrible insects and do not deserve to have wings.
d. Because he hit himself, the fly should have been killed.

2. Which of the following best describes the fly in this story?

a. playful
b. sinister
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3. Which word below could replace the underlined word *endeavoring* in the passage?

a. building up
b. memorizing
c. attempting
d. jumping

Chomp 8

1. **What is the main idea of this passage?**

a. Snowboarding is a dangerous sport, and not many people are willing to take the risks it involves.
b. Some ski resorts banned snowboarding because of the potential dangers it poses.
c. Snowboarding began with the "snurfer" and thousands of these were sold in the 1960s.
d. The history of snowboarding dates back to the 1960s, and the sport is becoming increasingly popular today.

2. What is a fanatic?

a. genius
b. athlete
c. expert
d. enthusiast

3. Today, snowboarders descend a slope that is covered with snow while standing on a board attached to a rider's feet using a special boot that is set onto a mounted binding.

ARA **Possible- resting in peace, gone to meet their maker, passed, crossed over**

Chomp 9

1. What is the *best* way for Jason to get started on his essay?

- **a.** ask his friends how they are going to answer the question
- **b.** create an outline based on opinions in the community
- **c.** look up different types of cars on the Internet
- **d. think about the topic and jot down some pros and cons**

2. In order to be effective, what will Jason's paper need to be?

- **a.** narrative
- **b.** persuasive
- **c.** informational
- **d. argumentative**

3. What would your "claim" be for this prompt? List some of your reasons for or against lowering the legal driving age. ARA Possible:

Reasons for	Reasons against
Help already busy parents with errands **Get to and from practices with greater ease** **Get a part-time job to help with family expenses**	**Immature – leads to careless mistakes while behind the wheel** **Higher insurance costs earlier for families** **Too much responsibility for a younger age**

Chomp 10

Read the following three sentences. Identify what is wrong, and correct each sentence.

1. Every day, my mom serves cookies to my friends on paper plates.

Everyday my mom serves cookies on paper plates to my friends.

2. We ate the popcorn that we had bought slowly.

We slowly ate the popcorn that we bought.

3. Covered with warm chocolate, the waitress served the hot cake to the customers.

The waitress served the hot cake covered with warm chocolate to the customers.

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